

THE TWO-YEAR TEST

Most of us lack Clancy's eloquence, but we have a tough time handling change. I confess to feeling a slight twinge now and then when I adjust my watch from daylight to standard time. But retiring is one of life's major changes. It's scary. Few changes work out exactly the way we expect them to. What if we're making a mistake?

But there's one thing you can do right now to prepare for retirement. I don't care if you're 45 and plan to retire at 65. I don't care if you're flat broke. I don't care if George Steinbrenner has just asked you to manage the Yankees. I don't care if you're newly wed, closing on a new house, or about to cash in big stock options. I don't care if you've just received urgent phone messages from Lawrence Tisch and John Gutfreund asking you to take their jobs. Wherever you are on your private career path, there's something you can do right now to design good timing into your future:

Take the two-year test

To take the two-year test, consider that the rest of your life is two years. Would you change anything? If you had only two years to live, would you continue to work where you work? Live where you live? Treat your spouse and kids the way you treat them now? See your friends as often as you do now? Travel about as much as you do now? If you answer yes to those questions, change nothing. All you have to do is retake the two-year test in six months or so.

If you answer no to any of those questions—if you'd do something differently if you knew you were to die in two years—you need to reflect a bit. What has happened in your life that makes you want to change? What alternatives do you see? How can you get started in a new direction?

A childhood mentor I'll call Mac taught me the two-year test. Mac was the father of my high-school flame. He's a jolly, playful guy who never bothered to grow up. He'd